

EARLY MILITARY JETS

ALTHOUGH THE GERMANS LED the way in the development of military jets during WWII (see pages 254–55), the British were not far behind. After successful experiments with the Gloster E.28/39, they built the first of the Gloster Meteor series, some of which flew in 1944. Initially using British jet engines, the Americans produced first the Airacomet and then the Shooting Star. Nearly all of these fighters had two engines, because a single-engined aircraft could not achieve an acceptable level of performance. Postwar jet fighters were characterized by the adoption of swept wings – an idea copied from the Germans – which reduced drag significantly at high subsonic speeds. Aircraft designers also took advantage of rapid advances in jet engine technology which made the thrust from a single engine more than adequate for such lightweight machines.

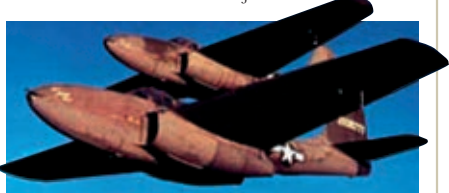
MIG INSPECTION

A North Korean defector's MiG-15 (the F-86 Sabre's main opponent in the Korean War) is inspected by USAF personnel. See pages 280–81.



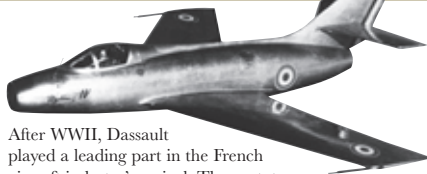
Bell P-59B Airacomet

The British shared the secret of jet flight with the Americans in June 1941 by sending them a Whittle engine prototype. Bell designed a twin-engined aircraft and in October 1942, the Bell-built General Electric powered P-59 became the first American jet.



ENGINE 2 x 2,000lb (910kg) thrust GE J31-GE-3 turbojet	
WINGSPAN 45ft 6in (13.9m)	LENGTH 38ft 2in (11.6m)
TOP SPEED 409mph (658kph)	CREW 1
ARMAMENT 1 x 37mm M4 cannon, 3 x .5in machine guns	

Dassault Mystère IVA



After WWII, Dassault played a leading part in the French aircraft industry's revival. The prototype Mystère flew in September 1952 and the French Air Force began receiving the IVA in 1955. The following year, during the Suez Crisis, Mystère IVAs flown by French and Israeli Air Force pilots, fought against Egyptian Air Force MiG-15s and MiG-17s.

ENGINE 6,280lb (2,855kg) thrust Hispano-Suiza Tay 250A turbojet	
WINGSPAN 36ft 6in (11.1m)	LENGTH 42ft 2in (12.9m)
TOP SPEED 696mph (1,114kph)	CREW 1
ARMAMENT 2 x 30mm DEFA 551 cannon; 2 x 1,000lb (455kg) bombs or 12 rockets	

de Havilland D.H.100 Vampire (F.1)

The second British jet fighter to enter service, the Vampire arrived too late to see action during WWII. As the engine and airframe were designed by the same company, much effort was put into matching the two together. This led to the twin-boom layout and short jet-pipe which increased the efficiency of the relatively low-powered jet. The Vampire was fast and maneuverable and equipped the first RAF aerobatic display team.

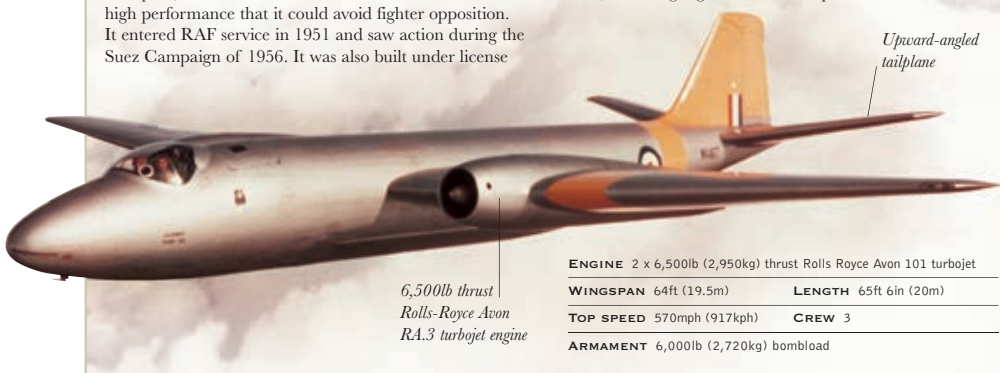


ENGINE 3,100lb (1,420kg) thrust de Havilland Goblin turbojet	
WINGSPAN 40ft (12.2m)	LENGTH 30ft 9in (9.4m)
TOP SPEED 540mph (869kph)	CREW 1
ARMAMENT 4 x 20mm Hispano cannon	

English Electric Canberra B.2

The first British jet bomber, the Canberra (B.1 shown) continued the concept already proved by the wartime Mosquito, of an unarmed medium bomber with such high performance that it could avoid fighter opposition. It entered RAF service in 1951 and saw action during the Suez Campaign of 1956. It was also built under license

in the United States and served with the USAF as the Martin B-57. The Canberra was also successful in other roles, including night intruder and photo-reconnaissance.



ENGINE 2 x 6,500lb (2,950kg) thrust Rolls Royce Avon 101 turbojet	
WINGSPAN 64ft (19.5m)	LENGTH 65ft 6in (20m)
TOP SPEED 570mph (917kph)	CREW 3
ARMAMENT 6,000lb (2,720kg) bombload	

Gloster E.28/39

The project to build the first British jet aircraft became a reality in 1940 when the Air Ministry issued a contract for an aircraft using the engine designed by Flight Lieutenant Frank Whittle. Whittle had lobbied for years to have his revolutionary idea taken up, and the E.28/39 made its first flight on May 15, 1941.



ENGINE 870lb (390kg) thrust Power Jets W.1 turbojet	
WINGSPAN 29ft (8.8m)	LENGTH 25ft 3in (7.6m)
TOP SPEED 466mph (749kph)	CREW 1
ARMAMENT None	